

Chapter 98_1 - Yiyi

Su Mo suddenly gripped the umbrella and took a few steps in pursuit, but saw that the woman's figure had already been enveloped by the misty rain, becoming ethereal like smoke. Finally, she turned out of the long street and disappeared.

She stumbled to a stop, rainwater still streaming down her face. She raised her hand to wipe it away, staring blankly at the glazed-colored leaves and eaves washed by the rain.

After leaving Su Mo's sight, Ning Fuyi turned and pressed against a red brick wall, raising her hand to look. Her well-proportioned hand had been soaked by rainwater until it wrinkled, white as the plaster on the wall.

She had pretended to be well-behaved in front of Su Mo for so long, and just now she had almost ruined everything, exposing the obsession in her heart. She sighed, raised her hand to remove the wetness from her body, and the raindrops could no longer fall on her.

Then she turned and walked into the deep alley. The white clothes on her body burned away like flames, replaced by black and red garments.

A moment later, she threw the already dry and folded white dress on the table. Hannya¹, who was dozing at the table, was startled into making a duck-like cry.

"Master?" Hannya touched her chest and stood up. "Why did you suddenly return? Were you driven out by that mortal again?"

"Mm." Ning Fuyi was too lazy to explain further. She pointed to the dress on the table and instructed: "Help me wrap this dress in cloth and send it back to the bamboo house."

Hannya agreed and put away the dress, but couldn't help muttering: "In this subordinate's opinion, you should just tie her up and bring her back to the demon realm. Wouldn't that be safer than the mortal world? You wouldn't have to pretend to be a grandson and suffer this humiliation every day."

"How can you speak like that?" Ning Fuyi picked up a peanut from the table and threw it into her collar. Hannya quickly shrank her neck to dodge.

Just then the door opened, and Jiuying² entered wearing a gold and red silk dress, her waist and arms exposed, walking gracefully. Upon seeing Ning Fuyi, she smiled and said: "Oh, what a rare guest today."

As she spoke, she placed all the things she had bought on the table. Looking around, they were all food or rouge and powder.

"I happened to be bored and went out for a stroll. Look, this roasted chicken from this shop is even more delicious than the one in Point Star Town." Jiuying unwrapped the oil paper, and the fragrant smell of meat immediately filled the room.

Hannya had already wrapped the dress and shook her head: "I'll trouble the divine beast to accompany master. This Hannya is going to compete with carrier pigeons for work."

With that, black energy overflowed, and she instantly transformed into a crow with shiny feathers, grabbing the package in her beak and fluttering into the drizzle.

"What happened?" Jiuying closed the window that Hannya had burst through, pulled over a chair to sit down, and poured Ning Fuyi a cup of peach blossom wine. "I could see you looking displeased as soon as I entered. What's wrong? Didn't it go smoothly?"

"It went smoothly enough." Ning Fuyi held the wine cup with her fingertips, tilted her head back and poured the clear wine into her mouth, then told Jiuying everything that had happened at the Qin manor in detail.

"Exchanging children to eat³? Tsk tsk." Jiuying distastefully flicked her nose with her fingertip, as if trying to flick away that putrid smell.

"The Divine Venerable has suffered, being entangled by such things daily. Not to mention she now has a mortal body - even if it were an inexperienced cultivator, they would probably collapse too." After speaking, Jiuying asked again, "But is your method really effective? If you ask me, why not just find some divine artifacts for her to carry for protection against evil? That might be more useful."

"How could I not have thought of that? But the yin-yang eyes⁴ themselves exist between the mortal and underworld realms. Although divine artifacts can ward off evil, they can also ward her off." Ning Fuyi shook her head. "Now that she knows those things approach her only to seek help, it should be better than before."

As Ning Fuyi spoke, she calmed down considerably and reached for the roasted chicken on the table, preparing to eat some with wine. But Jiuying suddenly snapped her fingers, as if remembering something: "Oh right, Shangchou sent a message this morning saying some demon realm 'Earth King' wants to challenge you to a fight. The battle letter has already been delivered to the Demon Abyss."

Ning Fuyi's hand, which was about to touch the roasted chicken, withdrew again, and she frowned: "Where did another Earth King pop up from?"

Over the years, people looking for trouble with her had been endless. The demon realm was naturally fragmented with various powers, and anyone with some fighting ability liked to declare themselves king. So in just thirty years, she had already defeated the East King, West King, South King, North King, as well as the Asura King, Hell King, and various other kings.

"Shangchou said he doesn't know. Anyway, the opponent came aggressively and looked difficult to deal with. He feared he would suffer defeat alone, so he wrote asking for help." Jiuying said, "There's also another matter."

She lowered her voice: "The Dread Hall sent word that Penglai has forged a magical artifact capable of eliminating you, planning to completely annihilate you at next year's Demon Slaying Conference."

Ever since the name "Dread Hall" spread among the people, Ning Fuyi found the title quite pleasing, so she actually did use the name Dread Hall externally, recruiting some cultivators and mortals from outside the demon realm who had nowhere else to turn, placing them throughout the mortal world and immortal sects.

She paused for a moment, then suddenly chuckled: "Do you think they really have such a thing?"

Jiuying shrugged noncommittally.

Ning Fuyi didn't reach for the roasted chicken either, wiping her hands and standing up: "Since that's the case, I'll return to the demon realm first. Please secretly look after Su Mo."

This matter came at just the right time, diverting her attention and giving her something to do.

"Demon Lord, take your time." Seeing Ning Fuyi's figure disappear, Jiuying grabbed the still-warm roasted chicken and enjoyed it alone with a smile.

Ning Fuyi's departure lasted several days. During these days, the human world encountered rainy season with daily continuous rain. The grass on the ground was pressed down by rainwater, and the river rose almost to overflow the wooden bridge.

The mountains were also inaccessible, so Su Mo could only sit under the eaves daily, gazing blankly at the lush green fields before her.

After the woman left, the rain hadn't stopped, and her heart had never calmed down either.

That day she had gotten angry and scolded her, even biting her hand. That bite must not have been light, or else why would she have tasted blood?

After the woman left, she naturally felt regret. The other party had clearly helped her overcome her fear, yet she had repaid kindness with resentment over trivial matters, speaking harshly to her. No wonder she left heartbroken.

Su Mo reached up to remove her veil, and the wind mixed with raindrops blew on her face, cool and refreshing.

She took out a small calming herb from the basket beside her, put it in her mouth to chew. The bitter taste flowed from her mouth to her nose.

The woman's method was indeed effective. Since that day, she had never seen that thing again. Later she heard that the Qin family had collected the remains and planned to find an auspicious day for a grand burial.

Previously, she had always felt that the yin-yang eyes were a punishment from heaven, a symbol of her guilt. Now she suddenly realized that this thing wasn't entirely

harmful. After all, those spirits could only be seen by her, making her their only means of communication with the outside world.

Su Mo hugged her knees and put her face on her legs.

If she had known this would happen, she should have asked more about the woman that day - where she lived, whether she had relatives or friends. Then she wouldn't be unable to find her like now.

Had she really been heartbroken and would never come back?

The sky grew increasingly dark. Su Mo looked up to see the beast-like mountains in the distance, slowly stood up, and returned to the small house that was darker than the mountains, lighting the candles the woman had left behind.

She mocked herself in her heart. It had only been a few days of acquaintance, yet she already cared so much. She must have grown accustomed to loneliness - the moment someone treated her a little kindly, she couldn't forget them.

She didn't want to be so dejected anymore, so she brewed a bowl of medicinal soup to drink, then went to bed early.

This night she still slept peacefully, with nothing coming to disturb her, except for the constant cawing of crows, though she couldn't hear them.

The next morning when she pushed open the door, she was surprised to find that the continuous drizzle of several days had actually stopped. The wind blew away the dark clouds, revealing a clear blue sky overhead. Morning light slanted through the cloud layers, making her bamboo house glow golden and brilliant.

She had intended to lift the water bucket to fetch some water for boiling, but just as she stepped outside, she discovered that the hillside not far away had somehow been excavated. Several strong men were carrying bricks, stones, and timber, huffing and puffing as they climbed the slope.

"Brothers, put some effort into it!" The men had cloth strips tied around their waists, their braids coiled on top of their heads, their bronze-colored skin glistening with oil under the morning light.

Life at the foot of the mountain was inconvenient, far less comfortable than in town. Why would anyone specifically move their residence here? Su Mo was very puzzled but didn't ask many questions, just watched from afar for a few glances before continuing to fetch water.

For the next several days, these men kept busy on the slope. Many people came and went during this time - some transporting yellow clay, some carrying bricks and tiles, and finally even desks and tea tables were moved over.

After many more days like this, when Su Mo opened her door again, a beautiful brick and tile house stood on the slope. The tiles used were the finest glazed tiles, gleaming brilliantly in the sunlight. The windows were carved with flowers, birds, fish, and insects. Flowers and plants were planted below the steps, and the courtyard wall was made of wooden railings, with the scenery inside clearly visible.

Without Su Mo knowing, someone had already moved in. But Su Mo hadn't seen what the neighbor looked like - she only knew that the windows would open during the day, and when evening came and it was time to sleep, flickering candlelight would show through the window lattice.

"Liu Dieyi"⁵ never returned. Su Mo concluded that she had been heartbroken and no longer wanted to deal with her, so after feeling sad for a few days, her feelings faded.

Fortunately, now she had a neighbor, so she wasn't completely alone.

But this neighbor was somewhat strange - no cooking smoke ever came from the chimney in the evenings. After watching for several days, Su Mo finally couldn't help but worry and decided to knock on the door to check.

If it were before, she would have wanted to hide from people as far as possible, but since "Liu Dieyi" had visited, her wariness toward people had gradually diminished.

However, she still wrapped three layers of veils around her face, then carried some medicinal herbs and walked to the front door, reaching out to knock.

But unexpectedly, just as her knuckles touched the cold wooden door, it creaked open. The smell of medicinal soup and blood rushed through the door crack into her nostrils, and Su Mo was stunned.

She quickly knocked on the door frame again to show politeness.

Footnotes

1. **Hannya (寒鸦)** - Literally means "cold crow," one of Ning Fuyi's demon subordinates
2. **Jiuying (九婴)** - A nine-headed mythological beast, one of Ning Fuyi's powerful subordinates
3. **Exchanging children to eat (易子而食)** - A historical term referring to the desperate practice during extreme famines where families would exchange children to consume, as they couldn't bear to eat their own
4. **Yin-yang eyes (阴阳眼)** - Supernatural sight that allows one to see ghosts and spirits invisible to normal people
5. **Liu Dieyi (柳蝶衣)** - The false name Ning Fuyi had given to Su Mo, meaning "Willow Butterfly Clothes"